How to Reference Visual Styles in Prompts

When creating content with AI tools, **referencing a specific visual style** is one of the easiest ways to control the final look. Whether you're generating images, animations, or character designs, calling out the *style by name* or *describing its traits* helps steer the AI.

Here's how to do it across the main tools in your course:

🧠 ChatGPT (for planning or generating visual ideas)

You can ask ChatGPT things like:

- *"Give me storyboard scene ideas in the style of 90s shonen anime."*
- *"What visual elements define the Ghibli animation style?"*
- *"How would a scene feel if I mixed Cyberpunk and Looney Tunes aesthetics?"*

Use style names directly — ChatGPT understands references like "Pixar," "Studio Ghibli," "Disney Renaissance," "Retro VHS anime," or "Samurai Jack." It can then help you **plan a story, tone, or visual flow** based on those cues.

🖼️ Midjourney / Leonardo / Stable Diffusion (for images)

These tools respond well to structure. Use the style reference in quotes or as part of your scene description. Example prompt:

- `"young warrior walking through neon Tokyo, cyberpunk anime style, high detail --ar 9:16"`
- `"post-apocalyptic wasteland, Studio Ghibli style, soft watercolor background, cinematic light"`
- `"underwater cafe, Adventure Time style, pastel, flat lighting, cartoon outlines"`

💡 *Tip: Add "in the style of [artist/series]" to reinforce it.*

🎞️ Runway / Sora (for video)

These tools mostly use reference images and text prompts. When writing text prompts, include style cues like:

- *"anime-style, with soft cinematic lighting, inspired by Cowboy Bebop"*
- *"dark VHS filter, 1980s anime action sequence look, flickering light"*

Runway also lets you **train or reference visual consistency,** so referencing a style can be as simple as uploading a frame from a show with that look.

 Final Note:

Don't just name-drop. Combine **style names + core visual elements** like color palette, line quality, and lighting to make the style stick. Example:

> *"SpongeBob cartoon style, bold outlines, hyper-expressive faces, aquatic setting, saturated colors"*

This gives your prompt more power — and more accuracy.